# LEADERSHIP LESSONS *from the Life of* RASOOLULLAH ﷺ



MIRZA YAWAR BAIG

# Leadership Lessons From The Life Of Rasoolullah ﷺ

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# Table of Contents


*Foreword* ..... 9
*Preface* ..... 11
*The Opening* ..... 14
*Being Extraordinary* ..... 17
*What is Extraordinary Faith?* ..... 20
*The Extraordinary Goal* ..... 53
*Extraordinary Commitment* ..... 57
*Extraordinary Team* ..... 62
*Extraordinary Quality* ..... 79
*Complete Certainty In His Belief And Message* ..... 111
*Not Willing To Compromise His Message* ..... 131
*Putting Himself On The Line* ..... 136
*Resilience: Face The Brutal Facts + Absolute Faith In Success* ..... 140
*Goal Comes First: Before Personal Preferences* ..... 153
*Living His Message* ..... 163
*Risk Taking* ..... 166
*Sacrificing Short Term For Long Term* ..... 175
*Magnanimity And Forgiveness* ..... 194
*Transitioning From Person-led To Process-driven* ..... 202
*Brotherhood Of Faith* ..... 205
*New Bonds – Basis Of Friendship* ..... 211
*Not Being Rigid In Decision Making* ..... 214
*Succession Planning & Leadership Development* ..... 238
*Afterword* ..... 245
*Glossary Of Terms* ..... 253


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# What is Extraordinary Faith?

To look at the first of the extraordinary qualities that Rasoolullah ﷺ displayed in his character - Faith - I like to quote from Barbara Winters about the essential character of faith - the ability to trust enough to take risk.

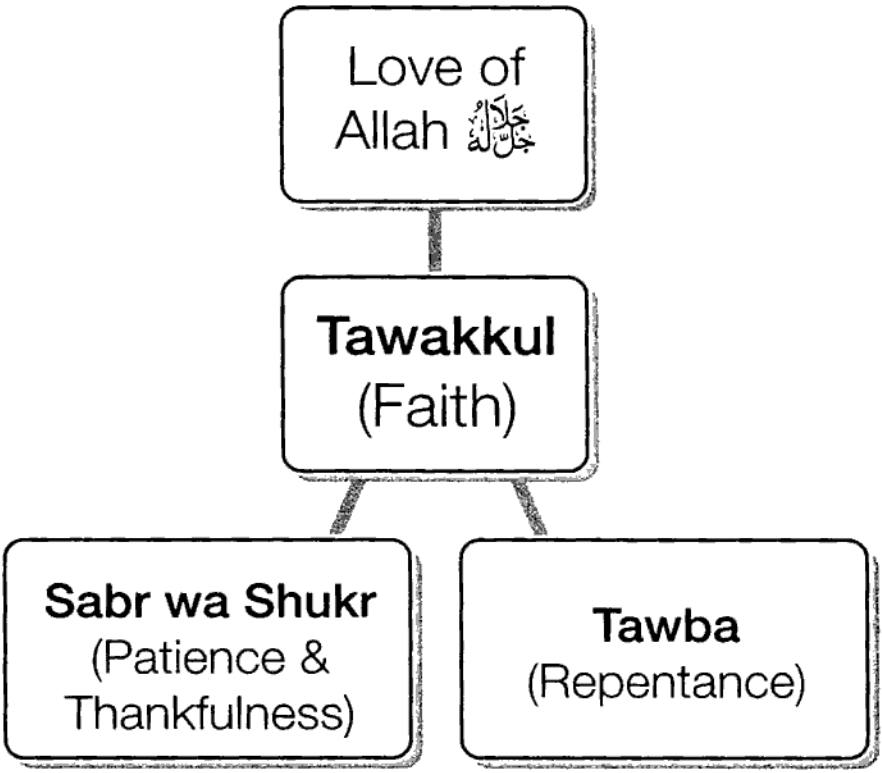
*"When you come to the end of the light of all that you know and are about to step off into the darkness of the unknown, faith is knowing that one of two things will happen. There will be something firm to stand on or you will be taught how to fly."* ~ Barbara Winters

Notice the use of words - she doesn't say, 'Faith is believing.' She says, 'Faith is knowing,' and in that is a world of difference. To believe with complete certainty without the possibility of doubt is to know. That is what enables one to take risk. To step off the edge knowing that you will not be allowed to crash; but that instead you will step on to another level of awareness and connection with Allâh ﷻ that you never thought possible.

Faith is essential because without it, the monumental task of changing people's hearts is impossible. It is a small word with big meaning. It means different things to different people. So let me define what I mean by 'Faith'.



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To me, faith is a dynamic process that is based on the interaction of three factors: Patience in the face of hardship and thankfulness for Allâh's ﷻ bounties; repentance for our transgressions and mistakes and seeking Allâh's ﷻ pleasure and closeness to Him by His worship because we love Him.

Faith, as Barbara Winters puts it, 'is to know' when there is no sign that one is right. Faith is not blind as the materialistic world likes to believe. Faith is to be able to see beyond material to that which can't be described or seen with the eyes of the head but which is clearly perceptible to the eyes of the heart. I recall an incident reported from World War II.

It was reported that after a very intense engagement with the Germans, a soldier asked permission from his officer to go into

no-man's land to bring back the body of his partner who had fallen during the battle. The officer tried to reason with the man and said, 'Look he is dead. What is the good of risking your life to bring back a dead body?' But the soldier was adamant and persistent and so in the end, the officer gave in and ordered the company to lay down covering fire while the soldier went out to the body of his friend. A few minutes later, he returned unharmed, with the body of his friend. The officer asked him, 'So was that worth risking your life? To get back a dead man?'

The soldier replied, 'Yes sir. It was worth it because when I reached him, he was still alive and said to me, 'I knew you would come for me.' He was waiting for me and he died in my arms. Yes sir, it was worth it.'

Faith is not blind. It sees what those without faith cannot see. It sees through the lens of love, of devotion, of gratitude for favors done – without reason. Faith is the yearning to be with the beloved. Faith lights the dark road of disappointment at the end of backbreaking effort because it knows that success and failure in this path is not measured in miles but by the willingness to stand up and make that effort to please the One who knows what is in your heart. Faith is the smile on the face of the one who walks on when all others have turned their backs because he is listening to a voice that they cannot hear.

As he walks, others stop to look and wonder; then slowly they turn around and join him until there is a caravan. They follow him because that gives them meaning and they find their own fulfillment.

Faith, in the language of Islam, is Tawakkul. About this Allâh ﷻ said:



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وَمَن يَتَّقِ اللَّهَ يَجْعَل لَّهُ مَخْرَجًا وَيَرْزُقْهُ مِنْ حَيْثُ لَا يَحْتَسِبُ وَمَن يَتَوَكَّلْ عَلَى اللَّهِ فَهُوَ حَسْبُهُ ....

***Talaaq 65:2-3*** *And for those who fear Allâh, He (always) prepares a way out (of difficulty), And He provides for him from (sources) he never could imagine. And if any one puts his trust in Allâh, sufficient is (Allâh) for him.*

Tawakkul or Faith is the result of three things as mentioned above.

**Tawba (Repentance)**

Allâh ﷻ orders us to make sincere repentance for our sins. Tawba is the first condition of guidance because Tawba indicates an attitude of wanting to change. No change or correction can happen unless a person is conscious of the need for it. So when we make Tawba, we are showing that we have become conscious of the need to change our attitudes and ways.

The first lesson that Allâh ﷻ taught Adam and Hawwa (AS) was Tawba. Both Adam & Hawwa (AS) and Iblîs disobeyed Allâh ﷻ. But the difference was in their attitude when they became conscious of their mistake. Adam and Hawwa (AS) were immediately contrite and repentant and said:

قَالَا رَبَّنَا ظَلَمْنَا أَنفُسَنَا وَإِن لَّمْ تَغْفِرْ لَنَا وَتَرْحَمْنَا لَنَكُونَنَّ مِنَ الْخَاسِرِينَ ﴿٢٣﴾

***A'araf 7:23*** *They said: "Our Rabb! We have wronged ourselves. If You don't forgive us and don't grant us Your Mercy, we shall certainly be of the losers."*

Allâh ﷻ forgave them and guided them and made them a source of guidance for others.

Iblîs, on the other hand, was not repentant and asked for time and said:

قَالَ فَأَنظِرْنِي إِلَىٰ يَوْمِ يُبْعَثُونَ ﴿١٤﴾

***A'araf 7:14*** *(Iblîs) said: "Allow me respite till the Day they are raised up."*

Today, when we are told to leave our evil ways, we ask for time. Let us reflect and see whose attitude we are reflecting; the attitude of Adam and Hawwa (AS) or the attitude of Iblîs (Shaytaan)? To insist on sin (Israar ala al ma'asee) is a reason for (Soo al Khaatima) a bad ending.

In Arabic we say, *'La kabeera ma'al Istighfaar wa la Shagheera ma'al Israar'* (There is no major sin with Tawba and there is no minor sin with insistence). Insisting on sin eventually results in the doors of Hidaya being shut and invites the wrath of Allâh ﷻ on our heads. Allâh ﷻ said about those who refuse to correct themselves and insist on sinning:

فَلَمَّا نَسُوا مَا ذُكِّرُوا بِهِ فَتَحْنَا عَلَيْهِمْ أَبْوَابَ كُلِّ شَيْءٍ حَتَّىٰ إِذَا فَرِحُوا بِمَا أُوتُوا أَخَذْنَاهُم بَغْتَةً فَإِذَا هُم مُّبْلِسُونَ ﴿٤٤﴾

***Al An'aam 6:44*** *Then, when they had forgotten all that they had been told to take to heart, We threw open to them the gates of all [good] things until -even as they were rejoicing in what they had been granted - We suddenly took them to task: and lo! They were broken in spirit.*



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*Allâh ﷻ is Ghayoor (proud, honorable) and after giving multiple opportunities to correct ourselves, when we insist on rebelliousness, He shuts the doors of Hidaya. Instead, He opens the doors of all that the rebellious person wants until he is immersed in his rebellion and then suddenly death comes upon him and he does not have the opportunity to make Tawba. We ask Allâh ﷻ to save us from such a fate.*

Allâh ﷻ warned us against all forms of disobedience and sin. One must not consider sins as being 'small or minor' because any sin is a sign of disobedience to Allâh ﷻ and such an attitude is a very serious matter. So it is not the specific action that one needs to look at but the whole matter of our attitude which leads to the Fire.

*Out of all sins, the worst sin is shirk and it is the only sin that Allâh ﷻ will never forgive, if one dies on it.*

Allâh ﷻ particularly warned us against cherry picking in the Deen things we like and leaving out what we don't like. This is the ultimate form of arrogance and invites the wrath of Allâh ﷻ. Today, there are Muslims who have legitimized all that Islam has prohibited and still they pray. They will not leave what Allâh ﷻ dislikes so with what face do they stand before Him and say: *Iyyaka Na'abudu wa iyyaka nastaeen* (Only You we worship and only from Your we ask help). This kind of arrogance – of taking what we like and discarding what we don't – leads to punishment both in this world and the next.

It is essential, therefore, that we make Istighfaar and Tawba immediately and instantly, leave everything that is disobedience to Allâh ﷻ and against the Sunnah of His Messenger ﷺ. How

long do we have before we need to do this? As long as we expect to live.

Tawba means to turn towards Allâh ﷻ and Istighfaar is the way to do it, by seeking Allâh's ﷻ forgiveness. The two are related and one follows the other. I have quoted from Imam Ibn Al Qayyim's book which explains the process very beautifully.

## The Meanings of Tawba and Istighfaar

### (Madaarijus Salikeen – Imam Ibn Al Qayyim)

*Scholars interpret Tawba (repentance) to mean all of the following: (i) immediate renunciation of the sin, (ii) firm intention and determination to not return to the sin ever again, (iii) regret over having committed a sin, and, if the sin was against the rights of another human being, then one must also, (iv) compensate for it. These are known to be the conditions of Tawba, or repentance. However, in the words of Allâh ﷻ and His Messenger ﷺ, Tawba has a wider meaning, and includes not only the aforementioned conditions, but also generally carrying out all the commandments of Allâh ﷻ with persistence. Tawba also requires disliking and renouncing those people who refuse to repent, encouraging them to repent and advising them against ignoring the practice of repentance. So repentance is the opposite of committing sins in every way, and in its general sense, does not consist merely of renouncing the sin and regret over it.*

*The essence of Tawba is to return to Allâh ﷻ and to adhere to what He loves and renounce that which He dislikes. Tawba is a journey (Hijra) from the disliked to the liked; from disobedience to obedience; from Allâh's ﷻ anger to His grace.*



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